

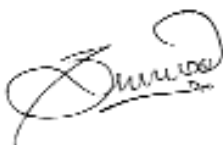
Social software

Social software make a virtual space useful for people who interact either directly by engaging in conversations, or indirectly where the consequences of people's actions and choices make it easier for other people to pick up the thread. Software such as blogs and forums are typically organised by time, while others such as Wikis and Amazon's recommendations are organised by topic.

The buzz is led of course, by tools such as Web log or blog software. Blogs are mostly a one to many communication medium, with the blog owner writing about whatever catches his fancy at any convenient time. The heavy cross-linking that is common among blogs, form communities of interest. By travelling these links, any chance visitor could discover a network of active people whose interests match his own. This spontaneous formation of communities exhibited by blogs is one of the key characteristics of social software—though less permanent networks can be formed over group Instant Messaging. Instead of the top-down mandated nature of a newsgroup or chat room typically run by a moderator, or channel operator, loosely connected blogging communities are formed and act purely by associations and reputation built within the community.

Similarly, an experimental tool from Microsoft called 'Three Degrees' does just that—help groups of people share discussions, music and other activities.

The power of a network grows exponentially with the number of connections. The momentum behind software that facilitates emergent networks, and let you carry your own social network online, in mediums that suit your needs is building. With the right tools becoming available, it is about time we reach out and connect with technology.



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“After the spectacular rejection of 'old' style IRC and Usenet groups, social software as a class of tools is now gaining mindshare on the Internet.”